INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION IN FOREIGN LANGUAGE TEACHING

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Outline

- What exactly is the intercultural communication competence?
- Intercultural Communication Competence (ICC)
- Concepts
- Why is ICC a needed component in teaching English as a foreign language?
- Strategies for developing multicultural lessons
- Our goals as teachers
- Conclusion

Aim of the PRESENTATION

To increase your awareness in terms of intercultural communication to achieve better results in teaching English as a foreign language and to point out that students from different backgrounds can achieve very good results in English if they are appreciated, not discriminated or stereotyped. When doing training in this field the following areas should be considered:

- Correcting ethnocentrism
- Dealing and avoiding stereotyping
- Increasing tolerance for anxiety and uncertainty when meeting "strangers"
- Increasing empathy
- Maintaining dignity and respect for strangers

“When in Rome, do as the Romans do”

What’s the meaning of this proverb?

According to the Cambridge Advanced Dictionary this proverb means *“…when you are visiting another country, you should behave like the people in that country”*. In this case the Roman behavior is the intercultural communication gap.

When people travel in different surroundings, they can face some challenges as it was the case with St.Augustine. If one is not aware of the culture, traditions, art in the country they travel, they can either face the **culture shock** or have problems with the locals. That is the reason why learning about other cultures is important. Not only for travelling or entertainment, but for other reasons such as education or business.

What is intercultural communication (IC) and intercultural communication competence (ICC)?

- Intercultural communication (IC) is the communication among those people who have so different cultural references that they perceive themselves as pertaining to different cultures
- IC provides people with different ways of thinking, seeing, hearing and interpreting the world;
- ICC - "An interculturaly competent speaker of a foreign language possesses both communicative competence in that language as well as particular skills, attitudes, values and knowledge about a culture"

ICC Concepts

- **Byram's model** in ICC whose concept is in accordance with linguistic competence, sociolinguistic competence and discourse competence (Han & Song, 176) combines knowledge, skills and discovery and interaction, intercultural attitudes and critical cultural awareness into a system of intercultural competence.
- **Bennet's model** of cultural competence - "Cultural competence is the process by which people learn to value and respond respectfully to people off all cultures." (p. 245). Bennett's model consists of a continuum of six stages moving from "ethnocentrism" to "ethnorelativism."
- **Process Model (D. Deardorff)** - *t*his model explains the process of how to become interculturally competent. The main elements needed to achieve ICC are attitudes, knowledge, skills, internal or external outcomes.
- **Gudykunsts's Anxiety/Uncertainty Management Theory** - based on the assumption that effective intercultural communication is essential for developing intercultural communication competence. Gudykunsts's theory introduced the terms anxiety and uncertainty when encountering strangers.

Bennett Model of Cultural Competency

ETHNOCENTRIC

DENIAL

DEFENSE

MINIMIZATION

ACCEPTANCE

ADAPTATION

INTEGRATION

ETHNORELATIVE

Cultural Competence is the process by which people learn to value And respond respectfully to people of all cultures.

STAGES OF CULTURAL COMPETENCE

DENIAL: Unaware of the existence of cultural differences.

DEFENSE: Acknowledge cultural differences but feel threatened by them. Methods used to defend against uncomfortable feelings are:
Denigration *Superiority* *Reversal*

MINIMIZATION: Minimize cultural differences in order to protect one's own cultural identity.

ACCEPTANCE: Recognize and value cultural differences without judging them as positive or negative.

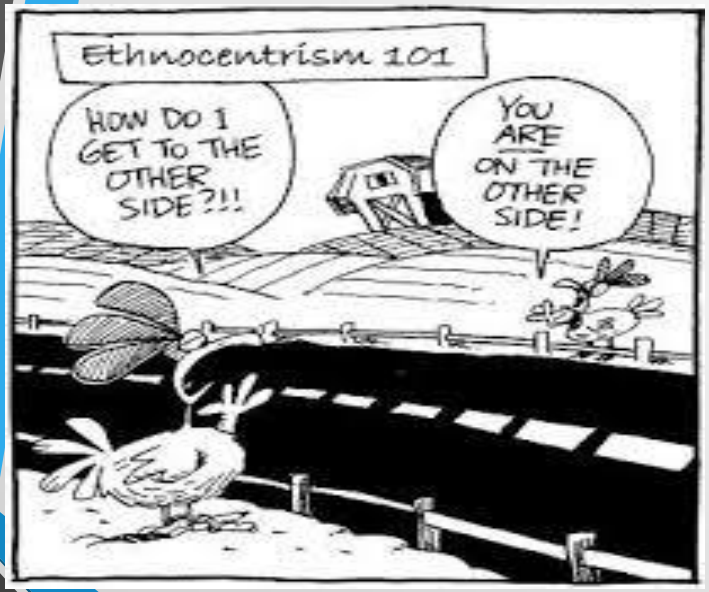
ADAPTATION: Adapt cognitively and behaviorally to cultural differences; Operate successfully within another culture.

INTEGRATION: Interact comfortably with a variety of cultures; Integration of cultural awareness into everyday interactions.

Bennett, M.J. (1993). Towards Ethnorelativism: A developmental model of intercultural sensitivity. In R.M. Paige (Ed.) *Education for the intercultural experience.* Yarmouth, ME: Intercultural Press.

Ethnocentrism self-test

- **GENE (Generalized Ethnocentrism)**



The **Generalized Ethnocentrism (GENE) Scale** is a psychological assessment tool designed to measure an individual's tendency to view their own culture as the central standard by which all other cultures are judged.

Appendix on: https://faculty.fiu.edu/~brownj/com3461/Ethnocentrism.pdf

Strategies for developing multicultural lessons

A multicultural classroom consists of students from different cultures which are supposed to form a diverse learning environment. To accomplish a relaxing environment the teacher should possess skills, creativity and knowledge.

However, teachers should not be blamed if they lack knowledge in this field because it is not known whether they have access to training programs of intercultural communication and multiculturalism(research in European countries, USA, Canada, China also point out lack of knowledge).

Ideas for multicultural lessons

- Role-play of interesting situations, (forum theatre)
- Access to literatures of different cultures
- Sharing knowledge about the students' cultures and origins
- Learning in groups with cooperation

- Positive and negative team debate on different topics
- Inter-ethnic projects – with the teachers and the parents

Incorporating ICC in foreign language teaching

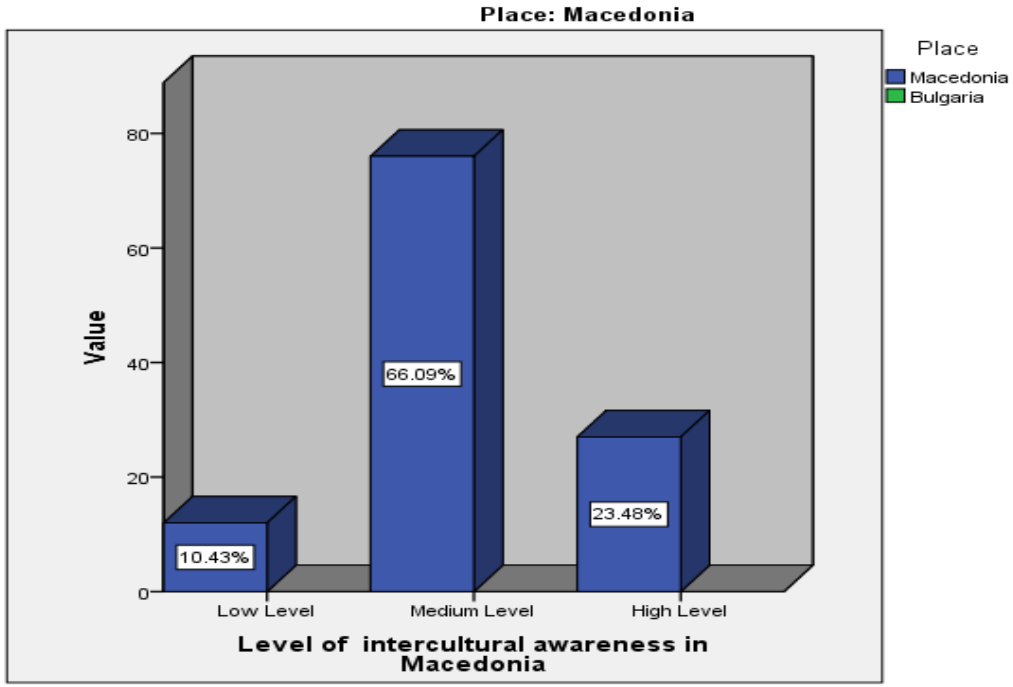
1. If students enter an intercultural classroom, the teachers must guide them and describe the environment and when this happens than the learning is learner-centered, engaging, interactive, participatory and cooperative.

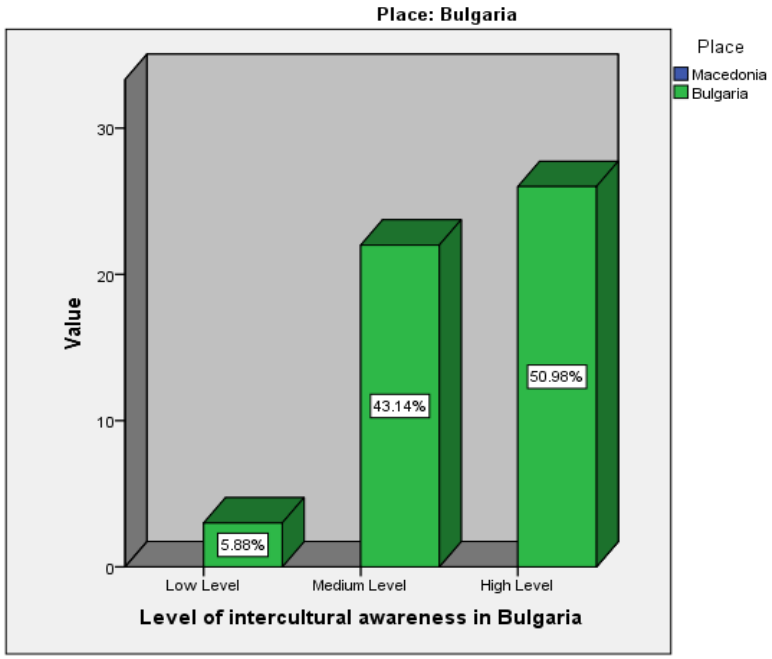
2. A language course concerned with culture broadens its scope from a focus of improving the four skills: reading, writing, listening and speaking in order to acquire **CULTURAL SKILLS** – the intercultural learner serves as a mediator b/n different social groups that use different languages and varieties.

3. If teachers become aware that language skills and knowledge need to be connected to the intercultural competence, students will feel that energy also and will show much better results. That is the reason why the intercultural competence is essential in achieving goals on an international level.

Why is ICC a needed component in FOREIGN LANGUAGE TEACHING?

Intercultural communication is becoming essential part of the education system nowadays because of globalization, immigration and the multicultural work environments. The need for training, knowledge and research in this field is increasing because of the recent trends in education.





Research results – Strumica vs. Ruse

Aims of ICC in Foreign Language teaching

- **The ultimate goal of an IC approach is not so much 'native speaker competence' but rather intercultural communicative competence and this includes the ability to understand the language and behavior of the target community and explain it to members of the 'home' community.**
- **IC approach – trains learners to be diplomats i.e. able to view different cultures from a perspective of INFORMED UNDERSTANDING and this aim displaces the long-standing objective of ELT – to attain 'native speaker proficiency'!**

Self – tests for ICC improvement

Personal Report of Intercultural Communication Apprehension (PRICA)2

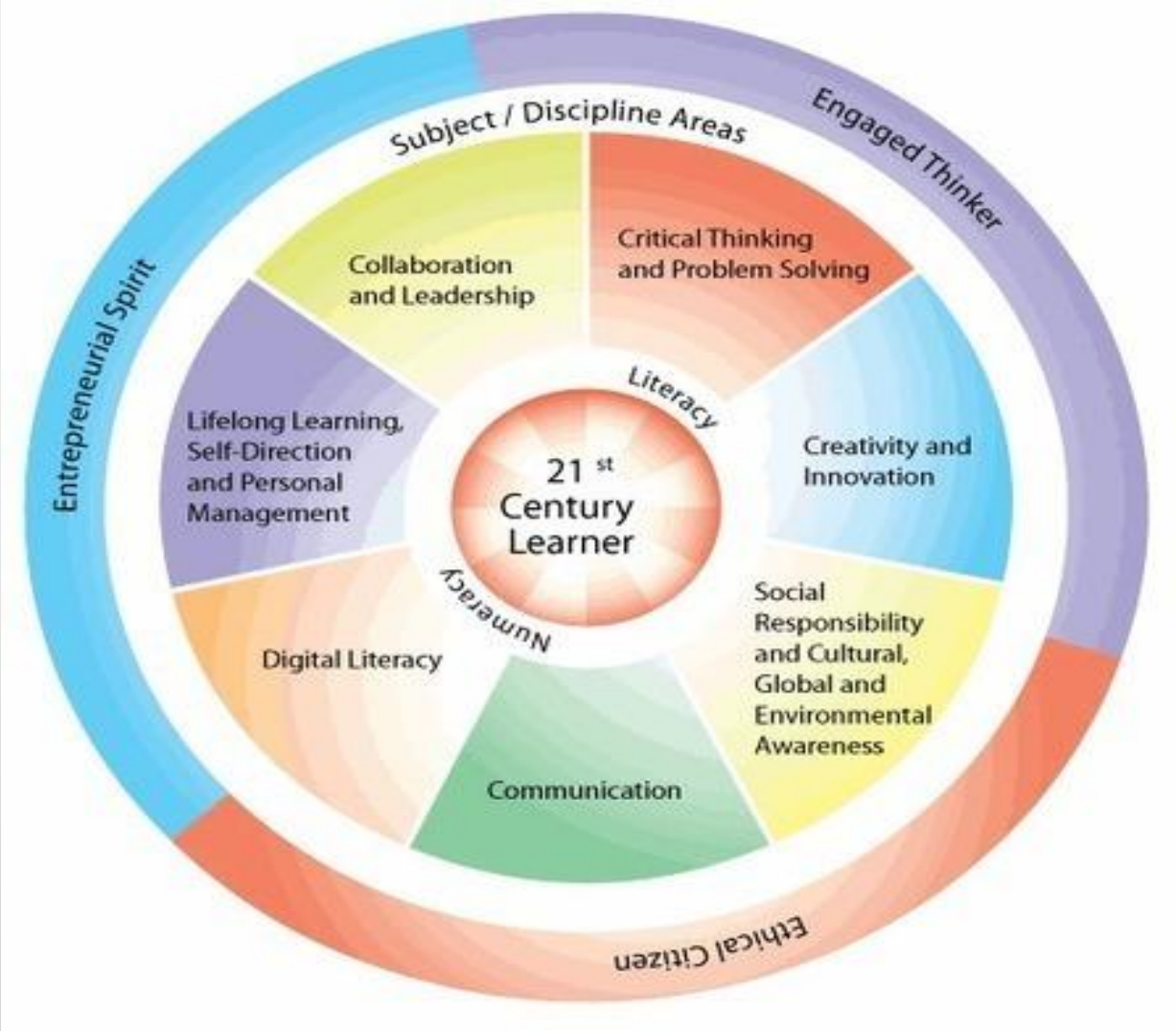
It is designed to measure the fear or anxiety an individual experiences when interacting, or anticipating interaction, with people from different cultural groups.

Appenix on:
https://www.jamescmccroskey.com/measures/prica.htm

Our goals as teachers

- Following the **recent trends** of intercultural communication of teachers
- We as teachers should make the students become aware that **stereotypes** should disappear and the system of values will have some potential of making the students understand that this world can be a peaceful place to live in
- **Improving inter-ethnic** relations but firstly with education of the parents, then the students and of course more trainings for the teachers
- **Skillful teachers** are crucial for the achievement of this proposed framework of intercultural competence

CONCLUSION


Subject / Discipline Areas
Engaged Thinker
Entrepreneurial Spirit
Ethical Citizen
Collaboration and Leadership
Critical Thinking and Problem Solving
Lifelong Learning, Self-Direction and Personal Management
Creativity and Innovation
Digital Literacy
Social Responsibility and Cultural, Global and Environmental Awareness
Communication
Literacy
Numeracy
21st Century Learner